SIMON THOMAS

HIGH PERFORMANCE LEADERSHIP · ATHLETES, COACHES AND PROGRAMS

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AUSTRALIAN PERMANENT RESIDENT · NEW ZEALAND CITIZEN · AVAILABLE FROM OCTOBER 2026

POSITION **High Performance Manager** ORGANISATION **Queensland Academy of Sport** REFERENCE **QAS701607 · Gold Coast**

BRIEF RESPONSE · WHY I AM BEST SUITED TO THIS ROLE WITH CONSIDERATION TO THE QAS VALUES AND BEHAVIOURS

Dear Selection Panel,

I am applying for the High Performance Manager role with the Queensland Academy of Sport. I read it as leadership that sits beside the coaches and support staff who wrap around the athlete at the centre. The athlete and program plan is the work and progression towards medal winning performance is the measure. My career began in that seat as a regional practitioner for High Performance Sport New Zealand supporting carded athletes in netball, hockey and athletics. It has since run through twenty years at the highest levels of rugby union and Major League Baseball player development, most recently holding the physical performance system across six player development sites for the Boston Red Sox. What I want next is closer daily work with coaches and athletes inside a program team with a clear line to Los Angeles 2028 and the home Games in 2032.

START WITH THE ATHLETE. OUR PEOPLE. OUR SUPERPOWER.

People First is one of my own values and I have always held that in performance support the athlete is a person first and an athlete second. At the Crusaders I held the annual planning of All Blacks and Māori All Blacks commitments alongside Super Rugby as one plan built around each athlete, balancing the needs of each week with the longer international calendar. I also hold that the science of stress and adaptation applies to coaches and support staff with equal force, so the people around the athlete deserve the same rigour in their development. At the Red Sox that has meant onboarding, development planning and a 360 degree coaching feedback process for sixteen practitioners, along with a proposal to club executives on extending performance science to coaching and support staff.

FREEDOM TO FLY. EMBRACE THE RESPONSIBILITY.

Meaning Over Status shapes how I lead, because being valuable to a program matters more than being needed by it. Those Red Sox practitioners work autonomously on site and report functionally to the coaches they sit beside, so the system only holds when people are trusted to make decisions and are clear about what they own. My aim in every role has been to build the system, grow the people and hand it over stronger than I found it. In this role I would be inside that trust from the other side, working to the Senior High Performance Manager with clear delegations and reporting.

BE CURIOUS. BE COURAGEOUS.

Rigour is Respect is the third value I hold, since careful work is how respect for athletes and coaches shows up in practice. Moving from rugby union into baseball meant learning a new sport and a very different system at major league level. I have also hosted two supported PhDs inside performance programs and set aside a block of every off season for professional development. Courage in this work is usually quieter than it sounds, such as offering a coach constructive challenge or raising a concern about an athlete's load early before caution compounds through the layers of a program into inaction.

UNITED BY EXCELLENCE.

I believe performance is the product of the environment around it and that stated values only build culture when processes are designed to carry them. At the Crusaders I worked alongside the head coach on season themes that the group helped build and then owned. Touring with the Māori All Blacks and world championship windows with New Zealand Under 20 showed me what the international stage asks of athletes. The club won four Super Rugby titles from 2017 to 2020 with coaches, medical, performance and management staff working to one standard. That is the same collaboration across NSOs, SSOs and QAS teams this role depends on.

There are parts of this role I would be learning. My Australian experience is in professional rugby rather than the national institute network, I have not managed Olympic sport programs through an NSO and SSO partnership and I have not worked within the Queensland public sector. I would close those gaps by listening first to the coaches, NSO staff and Senior High Performance Manager who already hold that knowledge. I hold Australian permanent residency and I am available from October 2026 with a relocation to the Gold Coast. My current résumé is attached and names an Australian referee who managed me within the past two years, with a Boston Red Sox reference available on request. I have also prepared an assessment of my fit against the role description and the QAS values, which I can provide to the panel on request.

Yours sincerely,

SIMON THOMAS

